

South Vietnam's Negotiation of American Influence

Walker Birchfield

History 495-The Global Vietnam War, 1945-1989

December 15, 2025

The birth of the Republic of Vietnam (RVN) in 1954 was rooted in the promise of a modern, prosperous future that sharply contrasted the current climate and reality on the ground. Following the Geneva Accords which led to the separation of North and South Vietnam, the state immediately faced multiple institutional and infrastructural challenges. The French colonial system that was previously established created a decaying legacy where utilities were unreliable, roads were unkept, and public services struggled to function. This legacy had prioritized military control and the extraction of resources over continual public service development that led to an infrastructural vacuum once the French had left Vietnam. Utilities became increasingly unreliable, public services struggled to function, and multiple societal frameworks began to crumble. This extreme fragility was visible prominently in the educational system, where failure was pervasive to the entire country. Classrooms suffered from overcrowding, teacher's duties were stretched thin between an abundance of students, and essential resources such as textbooks were nonexistent.

On top of this, there was an overwhelming influx of refugees that entered South Vietnam. "Operation Passage to Freedom" facilitated by the United States Navy, brought approximately 900,000 new refugees from North to South Vietnam. This even put an immediate and unsustainable burden on housing, resources, and a continuous struggle in the daily lives of both previous inhabitants of South Vietnam as well as these new refugees.¹ This initial massive effort to resettle North Vietnamese people into South Vietnam instantly normalized high levels of external administrative and financial support in South Vietnam. The United States intervening shifted South Vietnam from a newly independent nation to one reliant on foreign logistics and management from its very early inception.

¹ Operation Passage to Freedom Evacuates Refugees from North Vietnam: Research Starters: EBSCO Research." EBSCO.

The South Vietnamese government's strict control over the optics of American assistance was seen as a necessary strategy to manage its own domestic legitimacy. The newly forced Republic of Vietnam had to compete for the minds of its citizens against the North Vietnamese while also having the remnants of their French colonial reliance. Accepting foreign support from the United States, while economically essential, posed an internal threat of defining South Vietnam as an extension of the United States. If this is how the South Vietnamese people view the alliance, it undermines South Vietnam's claims to national sovereignty and independence. South Vietnam placing strict rules on the United States' aid served as an exercise to project strength and autonomy. It served to show that the South Vietnamese government, not the American government, was in charge.

In response to the crisis that was taking place after the Geneva Convention, the United States offered a vision of modernization that was centered on primarily Western principles of efficiency and progress.² American advisors in South Vietnam sought to implement a more Westernized way of living, arguing that the existing Vietnamese structures were not able to meet the evolving demands of a typical modern society. However, this proposed transformation came at a critical cost. American-driven programs sought out to reorient the traditional Vietnamese style and priorities, which often disregarded existing local traditions, cultural norms, and established power structures.³ This approach promised material benefits, but also carried the risk of a loss of culture and tradition. The South Vietnamese population including administrators, teachers, and other leaders as well as everyday workers were not passive recipients of the foreign advisor's recommendations, but they became active participants in a crucial negotiation. Every

² Michigan State University Advisory Group. Report on the Organization of the Department of Education. Michigan State University, 1956.
<https://vietnamproject.archives.msu.edu/objects/159-547-36/>.

³Michigan State University Advisory Group. Report on the Organization of the Department of Education. Michigan State University, 1956.

citizen made their own decision on accepting and rejecting different aspects of this new recommended Westernized system based on a personal, as well as political, calculation regarding the sacrifice of culture and political autonomy necessary for modernization to their country as well as overall security.⁴

Traditional historical studies concerning the Vietnam War center on an American experience as well as military strategy and political decision-making in Washington and Saigon. The debate that typically follows the topic of the Vietnam War is America's ability to win the war if certain aspects went differently.⁵ While scholars such as Michael Kort have contributed significantly to this overall framework, this sort of approach tends to relegate the Vietnamese experience to a secondary position. This study deliberately pivots towards a new way of thinking and aligns with a recently growing body of scholars that emphasize non-military and Vietnamese dimensions of the conflict. Specifically, this includes the culture, social, and educational landscape of South Vietnam while also looking at military aspects through a different lens. By focusing on the roles of institutions such as the United States Information Agency and the impact of educational assistance programs in south vietnam, this analysis attempts to view the United States as an agent of culturalism in South Vietnam rather than simply a military ally. The United State's intervention in South Vietnam served as an active component in the identity formation of the Republic of Vietnam. The central argument that is established in this paper is that the South Vietnamese population had to engage in an active calculation of collaboration and resistance with the United States, selectively accepting American organizational resources, ideas, and material made for immediate stability, while simultaneously having to defend core cultural

⁴ Michigan State University Advisory Group. Report on the Organization of the Department of Education. Michigan State University, 1956.

⁵ Michael G. Kort, *The Vietnam War Reexamined* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2017).

beliefs and autonomy. United States intervention determined the legitimacy and independence of the Republic of Vietnam in the eyes of its own citizens as well as the rest of the world.⁶

The newly created Republic of Vietnam inherited a fragile institutional as well as physical environment. Decades of French colonial administration had put an emphasis on resource extraction and military control over South Vietnam leaving the essential infrastructure necessary for a more modern society and independent state in decay. Major roads and public utilities were either neglected or poorly maintained resulting in widespread infrastructural decay. Critically, the RVN was established with a weak governmental system in place.⁷ In a volatile political environment, foreign assistance was required for economic survival as well as stabilization and administrative management. A political institutional vacuum provided the United States with an immediate opportunity to establish its influence. The United States' foreign policy goals had two sides. One was to reduce the French administrative and cultural control while also simultaneously constructing an anti-Communist alternative to North Vietnam.⁸

The American drive to mold South Vietnam into a modern state extended beyond logistics and into organizational thought. The Michigan State University Advisory Group (MSUG) was funded by the U.S Agency for International Development (USAID) and operated between 1955 and 1962, focusing primarily on administration, public safety, and policing efforts.⁹ The MSUG's plan was to reform the fragile administrative system with one based on Western managerial efficiency. A 1956 MSUG report outlined proposed solutions and organizational structures for the new Department of Education, further indicating the level of

⁶ Michael G. Kort, *The Vietnam War Reexamined* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2017).

⁷ Fredrik Logevall, *The Origins of the Vietnam War* (New York: Longman, 2001)

⁸ Truong Thuy Dung & Ninh Xuan Thao, *Advancing Education in the War Context: The Cooperation of the Republic of Vietnam and the Asia Foundation in the Years 1956–1975*, *HNUE Journal of Science*

⁹ Michigan State University Advisory Group. *Report on the Organization of the Department of Education*. Michigan State University, 1956.

detail and control the American advisors sought to exercise in South Vietnam.¹⁰ MSUG's reform efforts did not occur in isolation. As Truong Thuy Dung and Ninh Zuan Thao argue, educational development in South Vietnam during the late 1950s and 1960s became a multilayered project shaped by various American organizations.¹¹ Their study of the Republic of Vietnam's cooperation with the Asia Foundation shows that the United States supported educational incentives consistently aimed to cultivate a new modern civic understanding of the new South Vietnam.¹²

The Asia Foundation funded libraries, civic education programs, textbook creation, and training for teachers. This allowed the United States to provide resources in order to support South Vietnamese schooling, but the resources were able to be reshaped however the United States wanted. Textbooks would be given to South Vietnamese children, but the textbooks also may place emphasis on American and Western values.

Despite an ideological weight behind these programs, it is important to recognize that, especially when referencing education, South Vietnamese acceptance of educational assistance was embraced. Most citizens in South Vietnam were content with accepting textbooks and educational materials from the United States because they addressed immediate needs that the South Vietnamese government could not address alone. Libraries funded by the Asia Foundation provided access to books in regions where, as an MSUG 1956 survey revealed, "not a single village has any type of library," which left entire regions in South Vietnam without reading material.¹³ American support was recognized as both appealing and essential. The construction of

¹⁰ Michigan State University Advisory Group. Report on the Organization of the Department of Education. Michigan State University, 1956.

¹¹ Truong Thuy Dung & Ninh Xuan Thao, Advancing Education in the War Context: The Cooperation of the Republic of Vietnam and the Asia Foundation in the Years 1956–1975, HNUE Journal of Science

¹² Truong Thuy Dung & Ninh Xuan Thao, Advancing Education in the War Context: The Cooperation of the Republic of Vietnam and the Asia Foundation in the Years 1956–1975, HNUE Journal of Science

¹³ Michigan State University Advisory Group. Report on the Organization of the Department of Education. Michigan State University, 1956.

school facilities, textbook distribution, and expansion of programs aimed at training educators filled in gaps in South Vietnamese society left by years of neglect. South Vietnamese officials were well aware of these deficiencies, and the current Ministry of Education's willingness to collaborate with the MSUG reflected a popular nation-wide acceptance that foreign assistance can accelerate the modernization of South Vietnam. This modernization is what was initially desired, so, especially to the South Vietnamese government, American resources were largely welcomed because they allowed South Vietnam to function smoother and demonstrate to its own population that the new government was capable of delivering these basic services to its people.

The South Vietnamese Government had always been able to control the conditions in which it accepted foreign support. While "Operation Passage to Freedom" was facilitated by the United States Navy, the logistical operation was initiated by Prime Minister Ngô Đình Diệm himself.¹⁴ Recognizing that the French would lack the capacity to help with such a mass evacuation, Diệm asked for assistance from President Eisenhower. Diệm attempted to frame this asking of support as a political opportunity managed by Saigon.¹⁵ By renaming the movement, "Operation Exodus" Diệm attempted to assert Vietnamese control over the operation even as he utilized American ships, American Personnel, and American Strategists.¹⁶ Furthermore, South Vietnamese government dictated specifics of the operation such as requiring United States Navy Personnel to be in civilian clothing while ashore and military markings had to be removed in order to preserve the appearance of South Vietnamese sovereignty.¹⁷ This early negotiation established a pattern that would be present for many more interactions between the two countries

¹⁴ Operation Passage to Freedom Evacuates Refugees from North Vietnam: Research Starters: EBSCO Research." EBSCO.

¹⁵ Operation Passage to Freedom Evacuates Refugees from North Vietnam: Research Starters: EBSCO Research." EBSCO.

¹⁶ Operation Passage to Freedom Evacuates Refugees from North Vietnam: Research Starters: EBSCO Research." EBSCO.

¹⁷ Operation Passage to Freedom Evacuates Refugees from North Vietnam: Research Starters: EBSCO Research." EBSCO.

in the future. The South Vietnamese government would selectively use American materials and support as long as it did not show apparent weakness or reliance on a foreign state. With a struggling government, there could be no risk to undermine the fragile legitimacy of the new state, especially in the eyes of their own citizens.

This pattern extended into the administrative sphere, specifically when looking at the MSUG and its implementation of Western efficiency. After years of working with and training under the MSUG advisors in subjects such as law, accounting, and economics, these programs led to successful newly founded administrative functions.¹⁸ One of these newly adopted functions was the launching of a national identification card program.¹⁹ However, by roughly 1958, the transfer of knowledge between the MSUG advisors and the Vietnamese was effective enough so that the Vietnamese instructors stopped relying on the MSUG advisors which significantly weakened the operational control of American advisors.²⁰ The South Vietnamese government eventually demonstrated this self-sufficiency of the MSUG trained citizens by terminating the university's contract, abruptly ending the entire program. The exercising of Diệm's right to not renew the contract shows South Vietnam's quest to accept support from external factors, but still be a sufficient nation without the reliance on an external nation.²¹

The most intense conflict between the MSUG and South Vietnam occurred over security reform. The MSUG advocated for a locally based Civil Guard built around communal units which was a model that reflected their broader nation-building Philosophy of decentralization for more efficiency. In contrast, officials and leaders in Saigon insisted on preserving the Civil

¹⁸ The MSU Vietnam Group Archive (Michigan State University, n.d.), <https://vietnamproject.archives.msu.edu/msu/>.

¹⁹ John Ernst, *Forging a Fateful Alliance: Michigan State University and the Vietnam War* (East Lansing: Michigan State University Press, 1998).

²⁰ John Ernst, *Forging a Fateful Alliance: Michigan State University and the Vietnam War* (East Lansing: Michigan State University Press, 1998)

²¹ Robert Scigliano and Guy H. Fox, *Technical Assistance In Vietnam: The Michigan State University Experience* (New York: Praeger, 1965).

Guard as a centralized, heavily armed force capable of carrying out policing functions on a national level.²² Ultimately, Saigon's vision won out and the refusal to adopt the MSUG's decentralized plan stalled the arrival of American equipment and also left the established Civil Guard unprepared for an escalating insurgency taking place. The MSUG wanted to reform the Civil Guard into one that resembles the US State Police system, but the rejection of this ideal meant that equipment the MSUG had already accumulated was not distributed until 1959.²³ The MSUG had already begun to start working on the restructuring of the Civil Guard with the assumption that the South Vietnamese government would accept the new structure. This is a critical point in the relationship between South Vietnam and MSUG where South Vietnam rejected the American administrative model, even if doing so ultimately undermined the Civil Guard's effectiveness. While American Advisors attempted to establish the same Western style system, it was not always accepted or implemented based on multiple factors.

This friction over the Civil guard revealed a fundamental disconnect between the South Vietnamese government and the American Advisors about the building of a new nation. The Americans viewed the state through a lens of administrative efficiency and stability. However, the South Vietnamese leadership believed in political survival and in order to achieve that, the consolidation of centralized authority was required. By rejecting the advisors model, the South Vietnamese government prioritized their own grip on power over technical efficiency of its own security forces. It is a crucial point that illustrates how the South Vietnamese government did not bow down to the Americans, and they did put their own values and priorities first. The

²² Robert Scigliano and Guy H. Fox, *Technical Assistance In Vietnam: The Michigan State University Experience* (New York: Praeger, 1965).

²³ Robert Scigliano and Guy H. Fox, *Technical Assistance In Vietnam: The Michigan State University Experience* (New York: Praeger, 1965).

negotiation here was not just about military strategy, but revolved around the security structure of the state as a whole.

Outside of the government, the United States realized the difficulty of reforming Vietnamese culture and establishing ideological control inside of South Vietnam. Despite extensive programs by the United States Information Agency (USIA) designed to push American democratic values, the missions suffered from a cultural ignorance by the programs managers. USIA officials did not fully understand Vietnamese culture leading to an ineffectiveness of their propaganda efforts.²⁴ The South Vietnamese people did not want to change their own culture or ideals just because another nation was present in the same location. If there was no apparent benefit to a changing of ideology, there would be no reason to do so. Recognizing this resistance to American messaging and American propaganda, the USIA shifted to using “gray” propaganda.²⁵ Gray propaganda was material that was produced by the United States, but it was designed to appear as if it originated from an independent source. The necessity of masking the source of this information helps see the extent to which South Vietnamese citizens will interact with American or foreign ideals depending on how much it benefits themselves. The USIA did employ a variety of psychological warfare tactics, including

In order to try to control the minds of the South Vietnamese people, the United States Information Service (USIS) worked jointly with the South Vietnamese Government to develop specialized tactics in order to gain political support. These initiatives were designed to bring South Vietnamese people together in order to have "greater support of their government and of the war against communist aggression."²⁶ These initiatives included the use of rumor teams,

²⁴ Wright, B. D. (2009). *Selling America, ignoring Vietnam : the United States Information Agency in Vietnam, 1954-1960*

²⁵ Memorandum From the Director of the United States Information Agency (Rowan) to President Johnson

²⁶ Memorandum From the Director of the United States Information Agency (Rowan) to President Johnson

cultural teams, and the distribution of tactical leaflets into South Vietnamese communities in order to create a sense within the community that communism was bad and the South Vietnamese government was good.²⁷ This joint effort between the two governments reveals many important aspects about both countries' goals. The South Vietnamese government's focus was on the support of the people, and they were willing to allow United States programs to infiltrate South Vietnamese communities in order to achieve their goal. On the other hand, the United States wanted to fight Communism so badly that the solution after traditional propaganda did not work was to secretly infiltrate South Vietnamese communities. While USIS proved its ability to rapidly develop and implement these strategies quickly after the initial propaganda did not work, and even achieved success in several smaller local areas, the overall program was widely considered vastly insufficient.²⁸ The mission's ability to sway the minds of the South Vietnamese was severely hindered by factors outside of the program's control. South Vietnam's long period of government instability as well as the United State's failure to provide basic security to citizens were identified as "overriding handicaps" in the "Memorandum From the Director of the United States Information Agency (Rowan) to President Johnson".²⁹

The failure of the USIA to bridge this cultural gap highlights the limitations that were present when their power is not aligned with their target audience. The American propaganda units operated with an assumption that ideological alignment with the South Vietnamese communities was a requirement of victory. A vision of democratic values was presented to a population that was focused on survival. Most people were not focused on changing their own

²⁷ Memorandum From the Director of the United States Information Agency (Rowan) to President Johnson

²⁸ Memorandum From the Director of the United States Information Agency (Rowan) to President Johnson

²⁹ Memorandum From the Director of the United States Information Agency (Rowan) to President Johnson

values, they were focused on staying alive and having a brighter future. For the average citizen, this political loyalty America wanted came through transactions rather than ideology. By attempting to use gray propaganda to solve their own problems, the United States fundamentally misunderstood the motivations of the Vietnamese people, who judged their partnership based on material aspects and security rather than persuaded ideals.

While the government's mission might not have been successful, the people of South Vietnam were willing to adapt their culture in other ways on their own terms. The escalation of the American military presence after 1965 rapidly increased the availability of consumer goods for the South Vietnamese citizens. In this sense, South Vietnamese citizens embraced American consumer inventions whether it be appliances or vehicles due to their ability to improve daily life.³⁰ While many of these American consumer items were never intended for the South Vietnamese, they ended up entering local black markets through the PX Program and the Commercial Import Program.³¹ Parallel to this material adoption, American popular culture became a significant social aspect in centers like Saigon. American music, fashion, and counter-culture became popular, and it was introduced to an impressionable youth who was facing a constant atmosphere of uncertainty.³² These outlets became a search for relaxation and optimism and allowed Vietnamese youth to be exposed to and utilize American concepts. This selective adoption and re-interpretation of removing the original context and repurposing it for local psychological benefits shows how cultural engagement and shifting operated in a space where overt political persuasion could not.

³⁰ "Selective Adoption of American Consumer Culture in South Vietnam," University of Texas Libraries Repository,

³¹ "Selective Adoption of American Consumer Culture in South Vietnam," University of Texas Libraries Repository,

³² "Music Revolution in Vietnam," Globalizing Vietnamese Music

This selective adoption of culture serves as a crucial part of history that is commonly overlooked when studying the Vietnam War. When South Vietnamese youth utilized American music or fashion, they were not submitting to cultural imperialism, but were rather repurposing American aspects into their own lives. In a war-torn society, American consumer goods and American ideas represented a momentary break from conflict and traditional expectations rather than an endorsement of United States policies and values. This viewpoint shows that the sense of Americanization in South Vietnam was a process of localized acceptance, where foreign goods were accepted and consumed on the South Vietnamese citizen's terms in order to cope with their current situation, and also a sign of the modern future to come. It was not a case of the South Vietnamese youth not becoming American, but the South Vietnamese youth using American resources during a time where trauma and fatigue plagued the entire nation.

These negotiations occur on every level of South Vietnam society. From the youth listening to American music, to the teachers accepting textbooks, all the way up to the official rejection of the decentralized Civil Guard, every decision collectively shaped the very identity of South Vietnam. The lasting legacy of this era was not a fully Americanized state, but a hybrid culture of South Vietnam and America. The combination of South Vietnamese priorities and traditions with organizational and material benefits from the West. This hybrid style of culture meant that even if the United States had achieved a full military victory, the result in South Vietnam would have been very different from the idealized, fully Western-style envisioned by the American advisors. The selective nature of the South Vietnamese citizens ensured that its modernization remained Vietnamese even when incorporating foreign resources.

Ultimately, the South Vietnamese Government and people both accepted and rejected different parts of America and introduced concepts on a personal basis guided by their own

calculation of self-interest. The governmental negotiation with the United States was driven by a balance of benefits and state sovereignty which led to Saigon accepting many logistical and fiscal resources while resisting organizational situations that threatened its own power.

Conversely, the people of South Vietnam engaged in a more cultural negotiation that separated material game and political ideology. They rejected the political message of USIA propaganda due to its lack of immediate benefits, yet enthusiastically embraced American consumer goods, not out of a loyalty to the United States, but out of a personal need. Each person has their own calculation that they themselves use in order to weigh the benefits and negatives of introducing new concepts, materials, or strategies into their lives or countries.

Bibliography

"Music Revolution in Vietnam." *Globalizing Vietnamese Music*. Accessed November 29, 2025.

<https://globalizingvnmusic.weebly.com/music-revolution-in-vietnam.html>.

"Operation Passage to Freedom Evacuates Refugees from North Vietnam: Research Starters."

EBSCO.

"Selective Adoption of American Consumer Culture in South Vietnam." University of Texas

Libraries Repository. Accessed November 30, 2025.

<https://repositories.lib.utexas.edu/items/70cad411-4877-4b67-85fb-0d8c4957cab9>.

Ernst, John. *Forging a Fateful Alliance: Michigan State University and the Vietnam War*. East

Lansing: Michigan State University Press, 1998.

Kort, Michael G. *The Vietnam War Reexamined*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2017.

Lodge, Henry Cabot. "Telegram From the Embassy in Vietnam to the Department of State." U.S.

Department of State, June 8, 1966.

<https://history.state.gov/historicaldocuments/frus1964-68v04/d153>.

Logevall, Fredrik. The Origins of the Vietnam War. New York: Longman, 2001.

Memorandum From the Director of the United States Information Agency (Rowan) to President Johnson. Washington, D.C., March 16, 1965. (<https://history.state.gov/historicaldocuments/frus1917-72PubDipv07/d37>).

Michigan State University Advisory Group. Report on the Organization of the Department of Education. Michigan State University, 1956.

Scigliano, Robert, and Guy H. Fox. Technical Assistance In Vietnam: The Michigan State University Experience. New York: Praeger, 1965.

The MSU Vietnam Group Archive. Michigan State University. Accessed November 22, 2025. <https://vietnamproject.archives.msu.edu/msu/>.

Truong Thuy Dung and Ninh Xuan Thao. "Advancing Education in the War Context: The Cooperation of the Republic of Vietnam and the Asia Foundation in the Years 1956–1975." HNUE Journal of Science (2024).

Wright, B. D. Selling America, ignoring Vietnam: the United States Information Agency in Vietnam, 1954-1960. MA thesis, University of British Columbia, 2009.